Specification of the controlled designation of origin "SAINT-EMILION"

approved by order of 27 July 2023, published in the JORF of 9 August 2023

CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion", initially recognised by the decree of 14 November 1936.

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

No specific provision.

III. – Colour and types of product

The controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion" is reserved for still red wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area:

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 1 January 2022: Saint-Christophe-des-Bardes, Saint-Emilion, Saint-Etienne-de-Lisse, Saint-Hippolyte, Saint-Laurent-des-Combes, Saint-Pey-d'Armens, Saint-Sulpice-de-Faleyrens, Vignonet and Libourne, for the part of its territory bounded to the south by the stream la Capelle and its extension as far as the by-road no. 28, by that road as far as the Dordogne and by the Bordeaux-Bergerac railway line.

2° – Delimited parcel area:

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the sessions of the competent national committee of 16 November 1938 and 3 May 2017.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

3° – Immediate proximity area:

The immediate proximity area, defined by derogation for the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines, is made up of the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 1 January 2022: Libourne, for the part of its territory not appearing in the geographical area, Lussac, Montagne, Néac, Pomerol, Puisseguin, Sainte-Colombe, Saint-Genès-de-Castillon, Saint-Magne-de-Castillon and Sainte-Terre.

V. – Grape varieties

1° – Grape varieties:

The wines come from the following varieties:

- main varieties: cabernet franc N, cabernet-sauvignon N, carmenère N, cot N (or malbec), merlot N;

- accessory variety: petit verdot N.

2° – Proportion rules on the holding:

The proportion of the petit verdot N variety may not be greater than 10 % of the grape varieties. The compliance of the grape varieties is assessed over all the parcels of the holding producing the wine of the controlled designation of origin.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

Products benefiting from the SIQO (official sign of quality and origin) “Saint-Emilion” come from either:

Holdings certified in organic farming including the production unit concerned by the SIQO;

Holdings certified at level 3 of the environmental certification of holdings, under the CRPM (Rural and Maritime Fishing Code);

Holdings certified at level 2 of the environmental certification of holdings, under the CRPM;

Holdings adhering to an approach benefiting from a recognition of total equivalence to level 2 of the environmental certification, under the CRPM;

Holdings adhering to an approach benefiting from a recognition of partial equivalence to level 2 of the environmental certification for the unit corresponding to the production of the SIQO, under the CRPM.

1° – Training methods:

a) – Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 5,500 plants per hectare. The spacing between rows may not be greater than 2 metres and the spacing between plants within the same row may not be less than 0.50 metre.

b) – Pruning rules.
Pruning is compulsory. It is carried out at the latest by the spread-leaves stage (Lorenz stage 9). The vines are pruned according to the following techniques favouring the spreading and aeration of the vegetation on a single trellising plane, while limiting the number of bunches:

- single Guyot or double Guyot pruning;

- spur pruning (cots) in Royat cordon or fan;

- long-wood (cane) pruning (astes).

Each plant bears a maximum of 12 free eyes (buds). In all cases, the overlapping of the long woods (canes) is prohibited.

c) – Trellising rules and foliage height.
The height of the trellised foliage is at least equal to 0.6 times the spacing between rows, the height of trellised foliage being measured at its lower limit at 0.10 metre below the bending wire and at its upper limit at the topping height.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel.
The average maximum load per parcel is fixed at 9,000 kilograms per hectare.

Where irrigation is authorised in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, the average maximum load per parcel of the irrigated parcels is fixed at 6,500 kilograms per hectare.

e) – Threshold for missing vines.
The percentage of dead or missing vine plants referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 20 %. Dead plants must be removed from the parcels; any storage of these dead plants on the parcels is prohibited.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition, the upkeep of its soil and the sanitary condition of the harvest. In particular, no parcel is left abandoned.

2° – Other cultivation practices:

In order to preserve the characteristics of the physical and biological environment that constitutes a fundamental element of the terroir:

- any substantial modification of the morphology of the relief and of the natural pedological sequence of the parcels intended for the production of the controlled designation of origin is prohibited, with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works;

- the addition of exogenous soil onto parcels of the delimited parcel area is prohibited. Exogenous soil means soil that does not come from the delimited parcel area of the appellation.

- total chemical weeding of the parcels is prohibited.

- every operator calculates and records its Treatment Frequency Index.

3° – Irrigation:

Irrigation during the vine's growing period may be authorised, in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, only in the event of persistent drought and when this disturbs the good physiological development of the vine and the good ripening of the grape.

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest:

a) – The wines come from grapes harvested at proper ripeness and presenting a good sanitary condition.

b) – Particular provisions for transport of the harvest. The use of the foulobenne (self-emptying skip fitted with a so-called centrifugal paddle pump) is prohibited.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes:

a) – Sugar content of the grapes. Grapes with a sugar content of less than the following may not be considered to be at proper ripeness:

- 194 grams per litre of must for the merlot N variety;

- 180 grams per litre of must for the other varieties.

b) – Minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume. The wines present a minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume of 11 %.

VIII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° – Yield:

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 53 hectolitres per hectare.

2° – Limit yield:

The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 65 hectolitres per hectare.

3° – Entry into production of young vines:

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the second year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the first year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 1st year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July and once the parcels no longer contain any

varieties other than those permitted for the appellation. By way of derogation, in the year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, the varieties permitted for the appellation may represent only 80 % of the grape varieties of each parcel concerned.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions:

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Blending of the varieties. The wines may not come from the accessory variety alone. The proportion of the accessory variety may not be greater than 10 % of the final blend of the packaged wine lot.

b) – Malolactic fermentation. Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) or packaged presents a malic acid content less than or equal to 0.30 gram per litre.

c) – Analytical standards. Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) or packaged presents a content of fermentable sugars (glucose and fructose) less than or equal to 3 grams per litre.

Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) presents a volatile acidity content less than or equal to 13.26 milliequivalents per litre, i.e. 0.79 gram per litre expressed as acetic acid (0.65 gram per litre expressed as H2SO4).

Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) presents a total SO2 content less than or equal to 140 milligrams per litre.

d) – Oenological practices and physical treatments. Subtractive enrichment techniques (SET) are authorised within the limit of a concentration rate of 15 %. After enrichment, the wines do not exceed a total alcoholic strength by volume of 13.5 %.

e) – Prohibited equipment. The use of the foulobenne (self-emptying skip fitted with a so-called centrifugal paddle pump) is prohibited. The use of the continuous-type press fitted with an endless screw of a diameter less than 400 millimetres is prohibited.

f) – Vat capacity. Every operator must have a vinification vat capacity at least equal to 1.5 times the average ten-year claimed production of the holding. The vinification capacity available at the time of harvest corresponds to the vinification containers.

g) – Overall upkeep of the cellar and equipment. The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep.

2° – Provisions by type of product:

The wines undergo ageing at least until 31 March of the year following that of the harvest.

3° – Provisions relating to packaging:

a) The wines are packaged from 31 March of the year following that of the harvest.

b) For each packaged lot, the operator sends to the approved control body, accompanying the prior packaging declaration, an analysis of the lot to be packaged carried out before packaging. For continuous or semi-continuous operators as defined in Chapter II, the analyses of the packaged lots are kept available for the approved control body in accordance with the provisions defined in the control or inspection plan.

4° – Provisions relating to storage:

The operator demonstrates a place suitable for the storage of the packaged products. A suitable place for the storage of packaged products means any place sheltered from bad weather (wind, rain) and protected from any contamination.

5° – Provisions relating to placing on the market for the consumer:

At the end of the ageing period, the wines are placed on the market for the consumer from 15 April of the year following that of the harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area:

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link:

The geographical area of the controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion", situated to the east of the town of Libourne, around the city of Saint-Emilion, is made up of a limestone plateau dominating the Dordogne to the south and bounded by the Barbanne stream to the north.

This territory extends over eight communes and part of the commune of Libourne, in the Gironde.

Parallel to the Dordogne, and its valley covered with vines, rises a first line of linear, steep hillsides, forming "combes", valleys in the shape of amphitheatres. It is in one of these, facing south, that the city of Saint-Emilion was built, a limestone medieval village with roofs of russet or grey tiles, girded with ramparts.

The corniche culminates at 100 metres in altitude, underlined by the holm oaks of the so-called "Mediterranean" belt.

At the centre of the vineyard, a limestone plateau with asteria dating from the Tertiary era remains. On this plateau, different types of soil are encountered:

- To the west of the city of Saint-Emilion, thin limestone soils of light texture (most often sandy-silty);

- To the east, essentially clay-limestone soils, not very heavy and not very thick;

- At the centre of the plateau, a fairly thick silty-clay cover.

Around this plateau, the so-called "Fronsadais" molasse (Oligocene) crops out on the slopes, generally more pronounced to the south and west than to the north. It most often bears limestone soils, whose texture is frequently clay-silty.

The north-west of the geographical area is covered by a sandy sheet (Quaternary alluvium) which locally contains a sandy-clay level. In places, the subsoils present an extremely high clay content. Near Pomerol (Figeac terrace), a series of gravelly knolls is encountered. To the south (Dordogne valley), Quaternary alluvium, made up of gravels, sands and silts, is distributed in a diversified way.

The extraction of stone has taken place at all times, leaving a network of galleries estimated at some hundred kilometres beneath Saint-Emilion and the surrounding plateaux. This network is frequently used as a cellar because the constant temperature, between 12 °C and 16 °C, and the humidity are perfectly suited to the conservation of the wines.

Continuing towards the North, undulating landscapes with gentle slopes succeed one another, almost exclusively planted with vines in close rows, punctuated by châteaux or old limestone buildings, and by copses.

The vines are often bordered by enclosure walls, made of rubble stone from the clearing of parcels for their cultivation.

This landscape, shaped by generations of people who have watched over the preservation and development of this heritage for centuries, is at once a witness of history yet living and evolving, which earned it inscription in 1999 on the UNESCO World Heritage list as a cultural landscape.

The "Saint-Emilion" region benefits from the temperate oceanic climate of the Bordeaux region, but more continental as it is situated to the east of the Gironde department. Temperatures are higher, with Mediterranean nuances, to which the presence of holm oaks testifies. The oceanic climate is unpredictable and accompanied in some years by a few rainy autumn depressions or, on the contrary, by warm and very sunny late seasons.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link:

This site, occupied very early by man, saw the vine arrive probably during the Roman occupation. Archaeological work has brought to light the remains of Roman villas and makes the site of Le Palat, near château Ausone, the most plausible residence for the famous poet-winegrower whose memory and name so strongly inhabit these places.

In 1152, the marriage of Eleanor of Aquitaine and King Henry II Plantagenet brought Aquitaine under English rule. Like many cities, Saint-Emilion, which had in the meantime become a very important centre of religious life with the establishment of the Collegiate church and its cloister, wished to acquire its rights. Widely confirmed in the 13th century, the rights acquired by the Charter of Falaise in 1199 would favour a considerable expansion of the vineyard under the English occupation. The creation of the port of Libourne in 1269 would widely open the route to wine shipments. The granting of new privileges by Edward I in 1289 confirms and extends the prerogatives of the "Jurade of Saint-Emilion" to the neighbouring parishes which would from then on form its jurisdiction.

On the eve of the Revolution, the "Saint-Emilion" vineyard is deeply marked by its land and socio-economic structures, which had evolved as early as the end of the Middle Ages. Whereas in other wine-growing regions of the Bordeaux area, there would be a direct passage from the feudal system to the constitution of large wine estates, the Libourne area is characterised by small farming units. They largely explain the extreme fragmentation of the present vineyard.

At the beginning of the 17th century, the surge in English and Dutch demand led to a tremendous expansion of the "Saint-Emilion" vineyard, whose area would double in the first third of the 18th century. At that time, on the hillsides, appeared plantations in "règes" (in trellised rows whose spacing is less than one metre), homogeneous with adapted varieties.

In 1884, the first wine-growers' union in France was created at "Saint-Emilion". It would be the ferment of the qualitative policy carried out since then on this vineyard.

Until the Revolution of 1789, it was the "Jurade" that ensured this role. A century later, the vote of the Law of 21 March 1884 allowing the agricultural world to create professional unions gives the wine-growers of "Saint-Emilion" new instruments to defend and promote their appellation.

1931 sees the creation, at "Saint-Emilion", of the first wine cooperative of the Bordeaux area: the union of producers of Saint-Emilion.

In 1936, the controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion" is defined by decree, its geographical area resting on the historic limits of the "Jurade of Saint-Emilion". In 2010, the "Saint-Emilion" vineyard, with an area of 5,500 hectares farmed by around 650 wine-growers, produces on average 230,000 hectolitres of red wines, part of which is claimed under the controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion grand cru".

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the product:

The wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion" is a dry still red wine. The main varieties are the merlot N variety, the cabernet franc N variety (locally called "bouchet") and the cabernet-sauvignon N variety. More anecdotally, the carmenère N variety and the cot N (or malbec) variety may be associated, as well as the petit verdot N variety, on an accessory basis.

The very largely predominant variety is the merlot N variety. It gives the wine its intense red colour, its alcoholic richness, its aromatic complexity evoking red and black fruits, as well as suppleness, roundness and silky tannins on the palate. The cabernet franc N variety gives the wine a slightly spicy aromatic finesse, a freshness and a more marked tannic structure. Finally, the cabernet-sauvignon N variety, less present, brings its spicy, complex notes and, through its tannic richness, favours a long conservation and gives harmonious wines.

3° – Causal interactions:

At the confluence of two rivers, the Isle and the Dordogne, the great wine-growing soils of the parcels delimited under the controlled designation of origin "Saint-Emilion" are mostly limestone and clay-

limestone. Limestone, clays, gravels, sands…, it is the quality of these soils, combined with the mesoclimate very favourable to the cultivation of the vine, that confer richness and complexity on the wines.

The merlot N variety has found on these unique sites its favourite ground. It particularly appreciates the fresh and humid character of the clay-textured soils where it ripens well.

The cabernet franc N variety is preferred on limestone soils or on slightly warmer textures (sands and gravels). The cabernet-sauvignon N variety is a late variety particularly suited to warm and dry soils (gravelly-sandy or well-exposed clay-limestone soils).

The adaptation of the work and of the choice of varieties to the diversity of the soils are know-how acquired from the experience of several generations of wine-growers always in search of improvement of their products. The climatic variations from one year to another also translate into marked organoleptic variations between vintages, a capital notion in the Bordeaux area.

The first wine-growing landscape labelled world heritage by UNESCO in 1999, the exceptional universal value of the site is recognised: 5,000 hectares of vines situated in the geographical area of the controlled designation of origin “Saint-Emilion” and eight communes forming the former jurisdiction of Saint-Emilion.

A site that constitutes the exceptional testimony of a cultural tradition and of a living civilisation, that of the vine and of wine, the combined work of nature and of man. It is the work of generations of wine-growers who have shaped, through their work, over the centuries, the hillsides and the combes of “Saint-Emilion”, that UNESCO has recognised.

XI. – Transitional measures

1° – Training method:

a) Parcels of vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009 and presenting a planting density between 4,000 plants per hectare and 5,500 plants per hectare continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up, subject to compliance with the trellising and foliage-height rules laid down in the present specification.

b) The provision relating to the spacing within the row does not apply to parcels of vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009. However, for parcels presenting a spacing within the row of less than 0.50 metre, only spur pruning (cots) or long-wood (cane) pruning (astes) without overlapping of the woods are authorised.

c) The trellising and foliage-height rules apply, for vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009, from the 2012 harvest.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° – General provisions

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin “Saint-Emilion” is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° – Particular provisions:

The labelling of the wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin may specify the larger geographical unit “Vin de Bordeaux” or “Grand Vin de Bordeaux”. The dimensions of the characters of the larger geographical unit are not greater, both in height and in width, than two thirds of those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Claim declaration:

The claim declaration is sent to the defence and management body before 15 February of the year following the harvest year.

It indicates:

- the designation claimed;

- the volume of the wine;

- the EVV or SIRET number;

- the name and address of the applicant;

- the place of storage of the wine.

It is accompanied by:

- a copy of the harvest declaration and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for buyers of grapes and musts;

- the cellar plan (place of vinification and storage), allowing in particular the number, designation and capacity of the containers to be identified.

2. Fallback (repli) declaration:

Every operator marketing a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin under a more general appellation makes the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of one month after this fallback.

3. Prior declaration of removals or packaging:

Every operator wishing to move or package wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin declares, to the approved control body, any bulk removal or packaging operation at least five working days before the operation.

Any operator who packages at least once a week for more than nine consecutive months in the year is considered a continuous packager. This operator is exempt from the prior declaration for each operation but must send half-yearly a copy of the handling register to the approved control body.

Any operator who packages at least once a week for more than three months in the year and less than nine successive months in the year is considered a semi-continuous packager. This operator is exempt from the prior declaration for each operation but must declare the packaging period(s) and send a copy of the handling register at the end of the indicated period to the approved control body.

4. Declaration relating to the dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine:

Every operator wishing to carry out a dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin makes the declaration thereof to the approved control body at least fifteen working days before the dispatch.

5. Downgrading declaration:

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin makes the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of one month after this downgrading.

6. Reworking of parcels:

Before any addition of soil or amendment, any development or any works modifying the soil profile or the morphology of the relief, with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works, a declaration is sent by the operator to the defence and management body at least two months before the start of the

envisaged works. The defence and management body transmits, within eight days, the copy of the declaration to the services of the National Institute of Origin and Quality.

CHAPTER III

I. – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A. – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1. – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area	Documentary check (using a geographic information system and the up-to-date CVI record) and check in the field
A2. – Claimable production potential (grape varieties and proportion rules, monitoring of transitional measures, planting density and trellising, abandoned vines)	Checks carried out: documentary (based on the CVI grape-variety record and the geographic information system data); in the field
A3. – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities. — Place of vinification	Documentary check and on-site check
Minimum vinification capacity	Documentary check (inventory of containers)
Traceability of packaging	Documentary check (register keeping) and on-site check
Storage place for packaged products	Documentary check and on-site check.
B. – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B.1 – Management of the vineyard. — Pruning	Counting of the number of free eyes (buds) per stock and description of the pruning method
Trellising rules and foliage height	Check in the field
Average maximum load per parcel	Check in the field in the six weeks preceding the harvest.
Cultivation condition of the vine	Check at the parcel. Vines are considered abandoned when: not pruned with a significant presence of woody plants other than the vine in the parcel, or not pruned with a significant presence of cryptogamic diseases
B.2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Particular harvesting provisions	Check in the field and on-site check (sorting of the harvest)
Ripeness of the grapes	Verification of the records at the operators'
B.3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Oenological practices or treatments (enrichment)	Documentary check and on-site check
Monitoring of the dates relating to packaging	Documentary check and on-site check
B.4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration. — Missing vines	Documentary check (up-to-date list) and check in the field
Authorised yield	Documentary check (check of declarations, yield increase for certain operators [monitoring of the authorisations granted by the INAO services, after enquiry by the said services upon individual request of the operator])
VSI, volumes harvested in excess of the authorised yield.	Documentary check (monitoring of destruction certificates)
Claim declaration	Documentary check and on-site check (compliance with the arrangements and deadlines, consistency with the harvest declaration, production declaration). Control of the placing into circulation of the products

C. – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Non-packaged wines, at removal	Analytical and organoleptic examination
Packaged wines	Analytical and organoleptic examination
Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory	Analytical and organoleptic examination of all the lots

II. – References concerning the control structure

National Institute of Origin and Quality (INAO),
TSA 30003,
93555 Montreuil Cedex,
telephone: (33) (0)1-73-30-38-00,
fax: (33) (0)1-73-30-38-04,
email: info@inao.gouv.fr.

The control of compliance with the present specification is carried out on the basis of an approved control plan and by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence and having received delegation from the INAO.